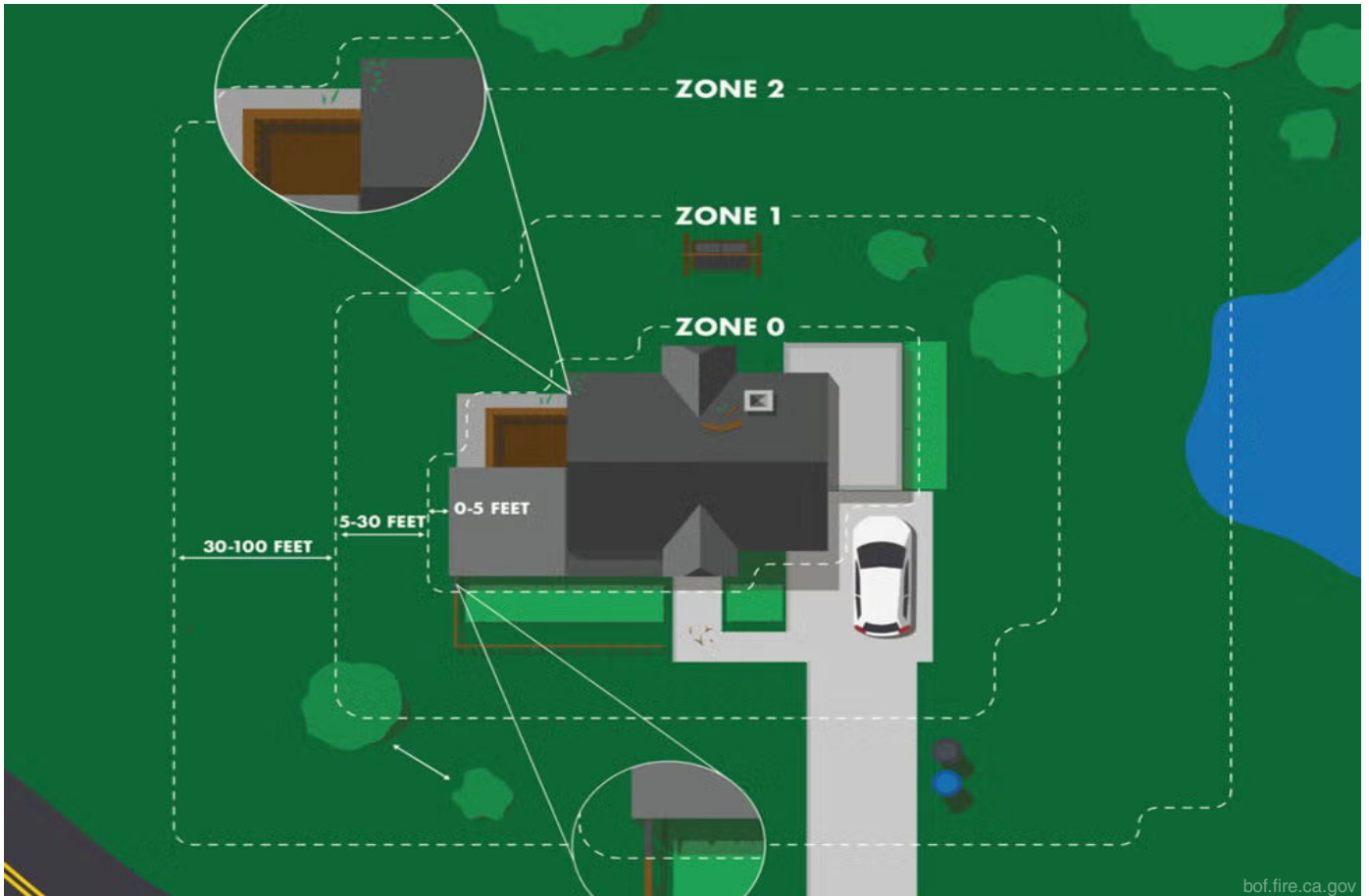




San Diego Zone Zero Compliance Packet

Everything San Diego County homeowners need to understand, prepare for, and achieve Zone Zero wildfire compliance before February 2027.

220,000+ San Diego homes in Very High Fire Zone	142,000+ acres affected in San Diego county	February 2027 compliance deadline
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01 | What Is Zone Zero?

The first five feet around your home are the most critical — and most overlooked.

Zone Zero refers to the area within **five feet of your home's exterior** — including attached decks, stairs, and porches. Fire science has established this as the single most important zone for preventing ember ignition during a wildfire.

Why embers — not flames — destroy homes: Research analyzing over 2,000 structures in San Diego County found that the majority of homes that burn during wildfires are ignited by wind-driven embers, not direct flame contact. These embers can travel miles ahead of a fire front and land in the combustible materials immediately surrounding your home.

Fire Science	"60–70% of homes burn because of embers," according to the Scripps Ranch Civic Association, which has helped hundreds of San Diego homeowners implement Zone Zero. Embers land on mulch, dry leaves, or wood fencing touching the structure — and that's where ignition begins.
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Legal Basis

- **California Assembly Bill 3074 (2020)** — directed creation of ember-resistant zones around structures in high fire hazard areas.
- **Governor Newsom Executive Order N-18-25 (2025)** — requiring the Board of Forestry to finalize Zone Zero regulations by December 31, 2025.
- **San Diego City Ordinance** — implements state mandate; new construction must comply now, existing owner-occupied homes by **February 2027**.
- **Rental properties** — Zone Zero applies immediately; compliance is required now, not in 2027.

ZONE ZERO 0–5 ft	ZONE ONE 5–30 ft	ZONE TWO 30–100 ft
Ember-resistant zone. No combustible materials. Hardscape, gravel, or bare soil only.	Reduce flammable materials. Maintain vegetation to slow fire spread toward structure.	Create fire buffer. Mow grass, space plants, remove dead vegetation and fallen leaves.
NEW REQUIREMENT Feb 2027 for existing homes	Existing requirement California law since 2005	Existing requirement California law since 2005

02 | Are You in a High-Risk Zone?

Zone Zero requirements only apply to properties in Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zones (VHFSZ).

Roughly **two-thirds of San Diego** — over 142,571 acres — lies within designated Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zones. That adds up to more than **220,000 properties** in the City of San Diego alone. Communities including Scripps Ranch, Rancho Peñasquitos, Carmel Valley, La Jolla, Del Mar, Poway, Escondido, and Encinitas are largely or entirely within these zones.

Check Your Property

Visit the **City of San Diego Fire Hazard Zone Map** at: sandiego.gov/fire/services/firesafety/hazardzone — enter your address to confirm whether your property falls within a Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone. CAL FIRE's statewide map is also available at: osfm.fire.ca.gov/divisions/wildfire-prevention-planning-research/fire-hazard-severity-zones

Communities Commonly Affected in San Diego County

University City	La Jolla	Del Mar	Rancho Santa Fe
Poway	Scripps Ranch	Rancho Peñasquitos	Carmel Valley
Clairemont	Encinitas	Escondido	Carlsbad
Mission Hills	North Park	South Park	University Heights

This list is not exhaustive. Use the official map link above to verify your specific address.

03 | What Must Be Done

Specific Zone Zero compliance requirements for existing San Diego homeowners.

The following requirements apply to all properties within Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zones. Existing owner-occupied homes must meet these standards by **February 2027**. Rental properties must comply **immediately**.

Must Be Removed or Eliminated

- Dead plants, dry or fallen leaves, and pine needles within 5 feet of structure
- All mulch and bark products within 5 feet (combustible mulch is the #1 ignition source)
- Firewood, lumber, and combustible stored items within 5 feet
- Trash cans and recycling bins within 5 feet of exterior walls
- Combustible fencing or gates directly attached to the structure (must be modified or separated)
- Vegetation touching exterior walls, eaves, or the underside of decks
- Dead leaves and debris from roofs, gutters, decks, porches, balconies, and stairways
- Propane tanks and combustible outdoor furniture within 5 feet
- Wooden trellises, planter boxes, or raised garden beds attached to the home
- Artificial and Natural grass yards

Permitted and Recommended Replacements

- Noncombustible ground cover: **gravel, decomposed granite, concrete, pavers, or bare soil**
- Potted plants with noncombustible containers (kept at least 3 ft from structure)
- Low-growing, fire-resistant plants (succulents)— if not touching the structure
- Metal or masonry fencing that does not connect combustible path to the structure
- Rock or stone garden beds as border material
- Concrete, brick, or pavers as patio and deck surround material

04 | FAQs

Does my wood deck need to be removed?	Decks are considered extensions of the structure. Zone Zero extends under and around attached decks. Combustible materials beneath decks must be cleared. The deck surface itself is subject to review.
Do mature trees need to need to come down?	No. Mature trees do not need to be removed as long as they are healthy and surrounding low vegetation is cleared. However, branches within 10 feet of roof or chimney must be trimmed.
What about my wood fence?	Wooden fences that directly connect to or touch the structure create a fuel path. These must be either removed or separated with a noncombustible gap (metal gate, masonry section) between the fence and the home.
Does this apply to my HOA community?	Yes. HOA common areas and individual properties within the designated zones must comply. HOAs should conduct a community-wide assessment and develop a compliance plan proactively.
How do I maintain a small lot with close neighbors?	Homeowners with minimal setbacks should focus on reducing fuel loads and working with neighbors to address shared radiant heat risks. Using "disconnected" planting islands or consulting UC Master Gardeners can help maintain aesthetics on small lots.
How will this be enforced?	Inspectors from CAL FIRE or local departments will conduct defensible space inspections to help you prioritize work. The focus is on education and risk reduction rather than immediate penalties.
Will this lower my insurance premium?	The California Department of Insurance requires companies to offer discounts to those who take necessary steps to protect their homes. Implementing Zone 0 is a key part of the "Safer from Wildfire" program recognized by many insurers. You should consult your specific provider to see if these mitigations impact your coverage.
Do I need to pay to receive for a certified inspection?	Yes. There is a \$125 fee for a qualified evaluator to visit your property and verify that wildfire mitigation measures have been properly implemented. After the inspection, regulators review the documentation and issue a certificate if your property meets the requirements.
Will artificial/natural grass need to be removed?	Yes. Both natural grass and synthetic turf are generally not compliant within the 0–5 foot Zone Zero area around a structure under California fire safety guidelines. Synthetic turf can melt or ignite from embers, while natural grass—dry or poorly maintained—can act as a fire fuel. Zone Zero requires a non-combustible perimeter, flammable landscaping materials like turf are discouraged in favor of hardscape surfaces.

05 | Zone Zero Diagram Guide

A breakdown of all three defensible space zones around your home.

California's defensible space law requires three distinct zones around every structure in a Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone. Zone Zero is the newest and most critical addition, addressing the primary pathway by which homes ignite during wildfires.

ZONE ZERO: 0–5 FT Ember-Resistant Zone

The ground immediately surrounding your home. Must be completely free of combustible materials. **Think: gravel, concrete, bare soil, pavers only.**

ZONE ONE: 5–30 FT Wildfire Risk Reduction Zone

Reduce flammable vegetation. Irrigate and maintain plants. Create horizontal spacing between shrubs. Remove dead vegetation and fallen debris. Ensure plants don't form a continuous fuel path toward the structure.

ZONE TWO: 30–100 FT Wildfire Buffer Zone

Slow the spread of wildfire toward the structure. Mow grass to 4 inches maximum. Create horizontal and vertical spacing between plants and trees. Prune lower branches of trees. Remove dead vegetation. Ensure outbuildings and propane tanks have 10 ft clearance.

Zone Zero Ground Cover: What's Allowed vs. Not Allowed

NOT ALLOWED in Zone Zero	ALLOWED in Zone Zero
Wood chip or bark mulch Pine needle mulch Rubber mulch Dry leaves and plant litter Wood fencing Wooden planter boxes Firewood or lumber Patio furniture (combustible) Trash, composting bins, or recycling cans Artificial turf Natural grass	Decomposed granite / gravel Concrete or pavers Bare soil River rock or flagstone Metal or masonry fencing Potted plants (in ceramic/metal pots, away from walls) Succulents (non-touching, low-growing) Irrigated fire-resistant plants

06 | Zone Zero Checklist

Use this self-assessment tool to score your property's Zone Zero readiness.

Review each item below and mark **Compliant (1)** or **Not Compliant (0)**. Total your score at the bottom. Keep a copy of this completed checklist — it can be shared with your contractor, HOA, or insurance provider.

Assessment Item	Compliant (1)	Not Compliant (0)	Notes / Action Required
ZONE ZERO — GROUND COVER			
No combustible mulch or bark within 5 ft of structure			
No wood chip ground cover within 5 ft of structure			
No pine needle mulch within 5 ft of structure			
Noncombustible ground cover used in 0–5 ft zone (gravel, concrete, pavers, or bare soil)			
No rubber mulch within 5 ft			
ZONE ZERO — VEGETATION			
No vegetation touching exterior walls, eaves, or siding			
No plants or shrubs growing beneath attached deck or stairs			
Low-growing plants (if any) are fire-resistant and not touching structure			
No dead or dry plants within 5 ft of structure			
ZONE ZERO — STORED ITEMS & DEBRIS			
Firewood stored away from structure (ideally 30+ ft)			
No trash or recycling cans within 5 ft of structure			
No combustible outdoor furniture within 5 ft			
No lumber, wood pallets, or stored materials within 5 ft			
ZONE ZERO — STRUCTURE & ATTACHMENTS			
No combustible fencing directly attached to structure			

Assessment Item	Compliant (1)	Not Compliant (0)	Notes / Action Required
Metal gate or noncombustible gap separates any wood fence from home			
Wooden deck surface and underside are clear of combustible debris			
No wooden trellises or planter boxes attached to exterior walls			
ZONE ZERO — ROOF & GUTTERS			
Roof is free of dead leaves, pine needles, and debris			
Gutters are clean and free of debris			
No dead vegetation in roof valleys or around chimney			
Chimney has a spark arrestor in place			
ZONE ZERO — VENTS & OPENINGS			
All foundation vents are screened with 1/8-inch or finer mesh			
Attic vents are ember-resistant (screened or baffled)			
Garage door gaps are minimal and not creating large openings			
ZONE ZERO — WINDOWS & DOORS			
Windows are dual-pane or tempered glass			
No combustible curtains or materials visible near windows in high-risk areas			
ZONE ONE (5–30 FT) CHECK			
Dead vegetation and leaves removed from Zone 1			
Plants properly spaced — no continuous fuel path toward structure			
Irrigation is functioning and plants are watered			
ZONE TWO (30–100 FT) CHECK			
Grass is mowed to 4 inches or less			

Assessment Item	Compliant (1)	Not Compliant (0)	Notes / Action Required
Trees have 6 ft of vertical clearance from lower branches to ground			
No dead trees or standing snags within 100 ft			
Trees near roof or chimney trimmed to 10 ft clearance			
Outbuildings and propane tanks have 10 ft of noncombustible clearance			
Six-inch clearance between ground and structure / deck underside			
TOTAL SCORE (count Compliant checkmarks)	—		

What Your Checklist Results Mean

Completing this checklist is an important first step toward Zone Zero compliance. Most homeowners discover a mix of compliant items and areas that need improvement — that’s completely normal.

This self-assessment is designed to help you identify obvious risks and begin making progress, especially in the critical 0–5 foot zone where most homes ignite during wildfires.

However, this checklist is not a substitute for a professional evaluation.

Pro Tip

Even if your score is high, your insurance company may still want documentation. A completed, dated copy of this checklist — signed and paired with photos — can serve as evidence of compliance progress when communicating with your insurer.

07 | Compliance Timeline & Enforcement

Key dates, deadlines, and what to expect from enforcement.

2020	AB 3074 Signed California Assembly Bill 3074 enacted, directing creation of ember-resistant Zone Zero rules for high fire hazard areas.
Feb 2025	Executive Order N-18-25 Governor Newsom issued executive order requiring the Board of Forestry to finalize Zone Zero rules by December 31, 2025.
Feb 2026	New Construction Compliance All new construction building permits in Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zones must demonstrate Zone Zero compliance at permit review.
Now	Rental Properties Zone Zero applies immediately to rental properties. If you own a rental home in San Diego's high-risk zones, compliance is required now.
Feb 2027	Existing Home Deadline All existing owner-occupied homes in Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zones must meet Zone Zero requirements. This is the primary compliance deadline for San Diego homeowners.
2027+	Ongoing Enforcement San Diego Fire-Rescue will prioritize education over citations initially, but insurance companies are expected to use compliance status in coverage and pricing decisions. Evaluators will prioritize homes in the red Very High Fire Severity Zone .
Act Early	Compliance costs are estimated at \$2,000–\$20,000 per home depending on property conditions. Contractor demand for Zone Zero work is expected to peak in 2026–2027. Homeowners who act now will face less competition, lower pricing, and have time to address issues before the deadline.

08 | Insurance Discounts

Zone Zero compliance can significantly reduce your homeowners' insurance premium.

California's **Safer from Wildfires** regulations require insurance companies to offer wildfire safety discounts to homeowners who take documented mitigation steps. This is a mandated program — not optional for insurers.

4 – 40%

Potential Premium Reduction

According to the California Department of Insurance, homeowners who comply with all steps in the Safer from Wildfires program — including Zone Zero — can reduce their premium by 4% to 40%, depending on proximity to wildfire-prone areas and their insurance company. This discount applies for the life of the policy, not just in the year compliance is achieved.

Steps to Unlock Your Discount

Step 1

Complete Your Zone Zero Assessment

Work through the Zone Zero Checklist. Document your current status with notes and photos.

Step 2

Make Required Improvements

Address any non-compliant items. Focus on Zone Zero first — insurance companies prioritize.

Step 3

Pursue IBHS Wildfire Prepared Home Designation

The Insurance Institute for Business & Home Safety (IBHS) Wildfire Prepared Home designation is recognized by major California insurers and can unlock the largest discounts.

Step 4

Notify Your Insurance Provider

Contact your insurer with your documentation. Ask specifically about the Safer from Wildfires discount program. If they are unaware of the mandate, cite California Insurance Code Section 675.1.

Step 5

Annual Review

Keep Zone Zero maintained year-round. Schedule an annual review to ensure continued compliance and discount eligibility.

09 | Next Steps & Resources

Everything you need to move from this packet to full compliance.

Your Recommended Action Plan

Check your property on the San Diego County Fire Hazard Zone map

osfm.fire.ca.gov/what-we-do/community-wildfire-preparedness-and-mitigation/fire-hazard-severity-zones

Complete the Zone Zero Checklist in this packet

Use the scoring guide to understand your current risk level

Take photos of your Zone Zero area for documentation

Date-stamped photos are valuable for both compliance records and insurance claims

Schedule a professional Zone Zero assessment

Contact San Diego Zone Zero Solutions: info@sdzonezero.com

Get contractor quotes for any required work

Start early — demand for compliant contractors will peak in 2026–2027

Notify your homeowners' insurance provider

Ask about Safer from Wildfires discounts once improvements are documented

Official Resources

Resource	URL
San Diego Fire Hazard Zone Map	sandiego.gov/fire/community-risk-reduction/fire-hazard-severity-zones
CAL FIRE Defensible Space Zones	bof.fire.ca.gov/projects-and-programs/defensible-space-zones-0-1-and-2
CA Dept. of Insurance	insurance.ca.gov
IBHS Wildfire Prepared Home	wildfireprepared.org
SD Fire-Rescue Community Risk Reduction	sandiego.gov/fire/community-risk-reduction

Ready to get your Zone Zero Score™?

San Diego Zone Zero Solutions provides professional compliance assessments, personalized improvement plans, and insurance documentation support for San Diego homeowners.

info@sdzonezero.com
sdzonezero.com

Free pilot assessments available for qualified San Diego homeowners. Contact us to apply.

San Diego Zone Zero Solutions provides independent educational assessments based on publicly available wildfire safety guidance. This service is not an official government inspection or certification. Always verify current regulations with the City of San Diego Fire-Rescue Department or CAL FIRE.